



The Role of Government in Reducing the Impacts of Agriculture on Water Quality

Trilateral Workshop on Water Quality

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Government plays a major role in the management of water...

Water is a finite resource; demands on this resource continue to increase; we will continue working together to ensure sufficient and high quality water for future use...

“Global freshwater consumption rose sixfold between 1900 and 1995 - more than twice the rate of population growth. About one third of the world's population already lives in countries considered to be water stressed”

Kofi Annan, Secretary-General of the United Nations, in *We The Peoples*, 2000

Public expectations and government responsibilities are significant...

With respect to water and agriculture...

- Safe and secure water supplies
- Access for all users
- High quality water for public and sectoral needs
- Increased public involvement in management
- Confidence in food safety and the agri-food industry
- Profitability of agri-food sector

In Canada, water and agriculture are shared responsibilities...

- Generally, the **Federal government** has jurisdiction with respect to natural resources issues - interprovincial and international
- Generally, the **Provinces/Territories** have primary responsibility for the management of natural resources that are fully within provincial borders
- Federal and provincial/territorial governments have **shared jurisdiction** over water and agriculture (among other responsibilities)
- **Key federal environmental (water) legislation** - Fisheries Act - is used with limited success for water conservation in agricultural context

The Canadian federal government currently has a water policy...

- **Federal Water Policy, 1987:**
 - Addresses supply and quality
 - Contains strategies on pricing, science, planning, legislation and public awareness
 - Includes policy statements on key national water issues
- **The water policy may be revitalized. AAFC is participating interdepartmentally through:**
 - Deputy Minister's Committee (ESDCC); Assistant Deputy Minister's Committee (IWAC); Federal science collaboration process (PAC)

There are many agriculture/water quality issues of importance in Canada...

- Global warming and increased climate variability
- Pesticide and nutrient runoff
- Larger and more livestock operations
- Full or over-allocation of water use rights
- Low priority for agriculture uses in water allocations
- Limited knowledge of groundwater resources
- Water quality for value added ag-processing

Shared jurisdiction has led to a federal-provincial approach...

- Canada has introduced an incentive-based, federal-provincial cooperative agreement - the Agricultural Policy Framework (APF)
- The APF is a framework with goals, objectives and public reporting in five main areas including the environment
- The environmental goals focus on air, soil, land, and biodiversity
- Programs are being designed to meet WTO green box status

Environmental Programming is being developed and implemented...

- Environmental programming includes:
 - Environmental Farm Planning (EFP)
 - Environmental Scans
 - Environmental Farm Plans
 - Beneficial Management Practices
 - GreenCover Canada
 - Reporting (NAHARP)
 - Information (NLWIS)

Environmental Programs will be monitored ...

Monitoring and reporting will...

- help ensure accountability and that the work gets done
- show change over time
- be useful in targeting and developing new programs

The Federal –Provincial Approach has common objectives...

- The Fed-Prov approach moves towards national consistency, but has built in provincial flexibility

Saskatchewan “*Safe Drinking Water Strategy*”

Saskatchewan Watershed Authority (Sask Environment) to provide technical assistance and regulatory guidance to the agri-food industry regarding water quality protection

Ontario “*Clean Water Strategy*”

Nutrient Management Act - regulates nutrients - development of nutrient management plans required

In Canada, Federal-Provincial collaboration will continue...

- Water issues cut across political boundaries and sectoral jurisdictions and can be considered a “horizontal file”
- We will continue to work together to share our approaches and developments - in policy, research and information - to promote sustainable management of our water resources

Canada-Mexico-United States have Common Goals...

- Sharing knowledge and expertise will help us address our common issues
 - Exploration of economic and policy instruments for water quality management
 - Sharing experiences with multi-stakeholder partnerships aimed at improving water quality
 - Sharing experiences in the development of scientific knowledge and decision support systems
 - Examining opportunities for collaboration to improve knowledge and improve management of shared water resources